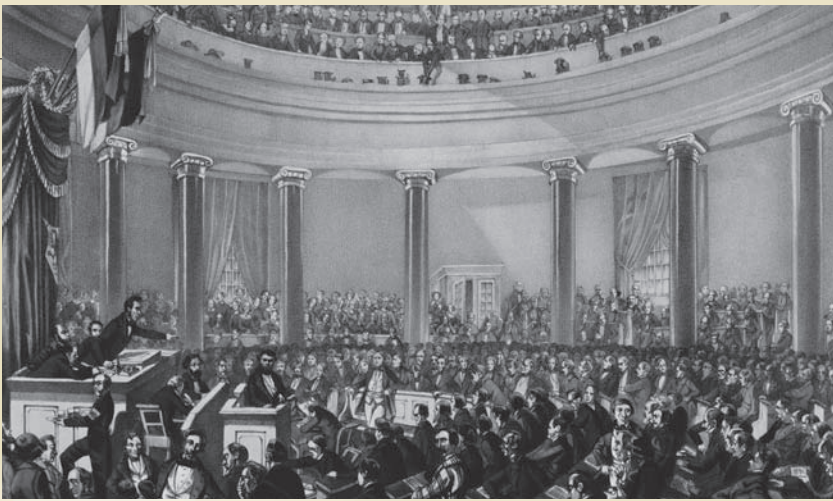




The Frankfurt Assembly

Representatives from all German states met in Frankfurt in the revolutionary year 1848 with the aim of uniting the country in a democratic way. They offered the role of king to Frederick William IV of Prussia, who refused what he called “a crown from the gutter.”

part and the Holy Roman Empire going to his brother, Ferdinand I; his Habsburg son Philip II inherits Spain.

1560s Calvinism spreads northward from Switzerland and establishes itself in Nassau, the Palatinate, and Ansbach, as well as making inroads into Hesse-Kassel and Brandenburg. Although Calvinism is excluded from the tolerance extended by the Peace of Augsburg, its main principle—allowing individual princes to decide their faith—allowed it to take root.

1618 The 30 Years War begins. Fought mainly between Catholic and Protestant states within Germany, the conflict starts in Bohemia but ends temporarily in 1623 with Protestant defeat and the occupation of the Lower Palatinate by imperial and Spanish troops. Intervention by Denmark in 1625 and then by Sweden in 1630 tilts the balance back in favor of Protestant states, but the intervention of France, a Catholic nation, against both imperial and Spanish Habsburgs in 1635 turns the conflict into a power struggle for control of Europe.

1648 By the Treaties of Westphalia that end the war, the Holy Roman Emperor recognizes the full religious and political sovereignty of the German states; territory is ceded to Sweden in the north and to France in the west. By the end of the war, Germany is economically devastated, and is now divided into numerous small kingdoms, principalities, and bishoprics. It becomes a backwater within Europe, fought over by Habsburgs, the French, and others. The Habsburgs continue to rule the empire, which now exists in name only, as real power, such as it is, is with the numerous small states.

1714 George, Elector of Hanover, becomes king of Great Britain; the electorate (after 1815, the kingdom) remains in personal union with Britain until 1837, when the Salic Law forbids the accession of Victoria to the throne and the two countries separate.

1740 Frederick II “the Great” of the Hohenzollern dynasty becomes king of Prussia. During his reign he establishes Prussia as a major power

in northern Germany, gaining Silesia during the War of the Austrian Succession in 1740–48 (which Austria fails to regain in the Seven Years War of 1756–63) and gaining Pomerania and East Prussia in the first partition of Poland in 1772. A benevolent despot at home, Frederick II concedes full religious tolerance, abolishes torture, and liberates state serfs.

1792 Prussia, along with Austria, declares war on revolutionary France as part of the First Coalition. By 1800, France’s armies have pushed the French eastern border up to the Rhine.

1793–95 In the second partition of Poland in 1793, Prussia, now ruled by Frederick William II, gains “greater Poland,” which includes Posen (Poznan) and Lodz, as well as Danzig (Gdansk). In 1795, in the third partition, Prussia gains Warsaw. The end of Poland is confirmed in a 1797 treaty.

1806 Following the defeat of the Habsburg monarch Francis I at Austerlitz in December 1805, Emperor Napoleon Bonaparte declares the Holy Roman Empire (or First German Reich) dissolved and creates a new Rhenish League—the Confederation of the Rhine—under his protectorship. This comprises 16 princedoms and cities including Bavaria, Hesse, Saxony, Westphalia, and Württemberg. Most of the rest of western Germany is absorbed directly into France.

1806 The Prussian army is defeated at Jena in October; the following year, Prussia allies with France.

1813 The Rhenish League breaks up after Napoleon is defeated at the Battle of the Nations at Leipzig in October 1813 following his retreat from Russia. It is replaced at the Congress of Vienna in 1814–15 by a new German confederation comprising 39 substantially independent states and with a diet (parliament) under the nominal presidency of Austria, although dominated by both Austria and Prussia, now the main power in northern Germany.

1834 To increase its relative authority inside the German Confederation, Prussia founds a German *Zollverein* (customs union) by merging the various existing north German *Zollvereinen* under its leadership. This abolishes the complicated system of intra-German tariffs and allows the relatively free trade of goods across much of northern Germany, promoting trade and industry. The individual states do, however, retain their own currencies. It also consolidates Prussian power, as Austria remains in favor of protection and outside the union. By 1852 the *Zollverein* includes all German states except Austria, the two Mecklenburgs, and various Hanseatic cities.

1848 Popular revolutions break out in many German states, temporarily overthrowing the monarchies. In Frankfurt a constituent assembly is elected and discusses the drafting of a national and liberal constitution for a united Germany. However, its offer of the German imperial crown to King Frederick William IV of Prussia is rejected by him, and opposed by Austria, while non-German minorities and German radicals refuse to accept the parliament. By 1849 Austrian and Prussian forces have repressed the revolutions and the old order is restored.

1870s A period of rapid expansion sees Germany become one of the major economic powers in the world.

1870–71 In a brief war with France, the French emperor Napoleon III is captured at Sedan and Paris besieged. By the Treaty of Frankfurt, France surrenders its two eastern provinces of Alsace and Lorraine.

1871 In January 1871 King Wilhelm I of Prussia is proclaimed emperor of Germany in the Hall of Mirrors in Versailles Palace, outside Paris. The new German empire has a federal constitution with many powers conceded to individual German states. These states keep their own monarchies and institutions, which leads to conflict between them and the imperial crown and parliament.

1873 Bismarck negotiates the League of the Three Emperors with Austria–Hungary and Russia; it lasts until 1890, when tensions between Austria and Russia over Bulgaria cause it to collapse.

1878 Major European powers meet in Berlin under Bismarck’s leadership to impose peace in the Balkans after the Russo-Turkish War of 1877–78. A second major congress in 1884–85 draws up the colonial map of Africa; by this stage, Germany is the diplomatic leader of Europe.

“Place in the hands of the king of Prussia the **strongest possible** military power, then he will be able to carry out the policy... through **blood and iron.**”

OTTO VON BISMARCK IN THE PRUSSIAN HOUSE OF DEPUTIES, JANUARY 28, 1886

1862 Otto von Bismarck becomes Chancellor of Prussia, a post he holds until 1890. First he gains Schleswig from Denmark in 1864 and then in the Seven Weeks War of 1866 defeats Austria at the Battle of Sadowa, forcing her out of German affairs. This results in the 1866 Peace of Prague which gives Prussia control of most of Germany north of the Main River. In 1867 a North German Confederation is formed which unites all the north German states but excludes the southern states of Baden, Bavaria, Hesse–Darmstadt, Lichtenberg, Württemberg, and Austria.

1879 Dual Alliance is agreed with Austria–Hungary.

1882 Triple Alliance is agreed with Austria–Hungary and Italy.

1884–85 Germany gains the African colonies of Togoland, Cameroon, South-West Africa, and German East Africa—its “place in the sun.” It also gains Qingdao in China in 1897 and Samoa in the South Pacific in 1899, as well as islands in the western Pacific.

Franco-Prussian war

An artillery unit of the 400,000-strong French army is here seen manning an outdated muzzle-loading cannon. During the conflict this proved no match for the power and range of the new German breech-loading cannon.

